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Robert Lowell

TWO TRANSLATIONS FROM GIACOMO LEOPARDI

A few paragraphs in Matthew Arnold's Lord Byron essay are the most commanding and intuitive criticism of Leopardi in English. We have nothing else perhaps of sufficient force and lightness; no one else makes us feel that Leopardi's meaning and meter are something we need if we are to write our own poetry. The Italians put him above any of their lyric poets except Petrarch, and feel more fervor for him than any of their writers except Dante. Like Goethe, Chenier, and Wordsworth, he modifies the rather philosophic and abstract style of the eighteenth century to make the major break-through of Romanticism. Twenty years earlier or later, he would have been impossible. No Romantic has written short poems of greater form and power; no poet in the world has written with greater pathos and exaltation of melancholia. Somehow his anguish is animated with joy and tenderness. Like Blake, he lives what he imagines.

In translating, I have used an unscanned line with occasional rhymes. If a line scans, this is an accident and no part of the rules I set myself. This is not far from the original meter of "Saturday Night." I have made no attempt to reproduce the Italian blank verse of "The Infinite."

"The Infinite," Leopardi's first great poem, is a miracle of compression and magical, casual rightness; its general sorrow and resignation tremble with the poet's person and nervous system. In "Saturday Night," the appalling, provincial little town breathes with all its bleakness and intimacy. Both poems show how Leopardi renewed and refreshed Italian poetry; each burns with a tradition that stretches back to the Romans.—R.L.

SATURDAY NIGHT IN THE VILLAGE

The day
is ready to close;
the girl takes the downward
path homeward from the vineyard,
and jumps from crevice to crevice
like a goat, as she holds a swath
of violets and roses
to decorate her hair and bodice
tomorrow as usual for the Sabbath.

Her grandmother sits,
facing the sun going out,
and spins and starts to reason
with the neighbors, and renew the day,
when she used to dress herself for the holiday
and dance away
the night—still quick and healthy,
with the boys, companions of her fairer season.

Once again the landscape is brown,
the sky drains to a pale blue,
shadows drop from mountain and thatch,
the young moon whitens.

As I catch
the clatter of small bells,
sounding in the holiday,
I can almost say
my heart takes comfort in the sound.
Children place their pickets
and sentinels,
and splash round and round

the village fountain.
 They jump like crickets,
 and make a happy sound.
 The field hand,
 who lives on nothing,
 marches home whistling,
 and gorges on the day of idleness at hand.

Then all's at peace;
 the lights are out;
 I hear the rasp of shavings,
 and the rapping hammer
 of the carpenter, working all night
 by lanternlight—
 hurrying and straining himself
 to increase his savings
 before the whitening day.

This is the most kind
 of the seven days; tomorrow, you will wait
 and pray for Sunday's boredom and anguish
 to be extinguished
 in the workdays' grind
 you anticipate.
 Lively boy,
 the only age you are alive
 is like this day of joy,
 a clear and breathless Saturday
 that heralds life's holiday.
 Rejoice, my child,
 this is the untroubled instant.
 Why should I undeceive you?
 Let it not grieve you,
 if the following days are slow to arrive.

THE INFINITE

That hill pushed off by itself was always dear
to me and the hedges near
it that cut away so much of the final horizon.
When I would sit there lost in deliberation,
I reasoned most on the interminable spaces
beyond all hills, on their antediluvian resignation
and silence that passes
beyond man's possibility.
Here for a little while my heart is quiet inside me;
and when the wind lifts roughing through the trees,
I set about comparing my silence to those voices,
and I think about the eternal, the dead seasons,
things here at hand and alive,
and all their reasons and choices.
It's sweet to destroy my mind
and go down
and wreck in this sea where I drown.